



The Silent Burden

Mental Health Challenges Among Child Labor

Presented by

Abdelaziz Taha, Christos Gregoriou, Jhann Torres, Sania Saleem, Ryan Poulson, Jack Cartmill, Ananya Bongoni



Overview(Abdelaziz Taha)



Child labor affects millions worldwide, but have you ever wondered about the silent burden that comes with child labor? Child labor, an ongoing problem our society faces, comes with more than what the eyes can see. The mental health struggles these children face often go unnoticed. From such a young age these children are introduced with stress, anxiety, depression, and emotional strain. These such challenges at such a young age hinder their emotional and long term development. According to studies done on the effects of child labor on mental health “As early anxiety and mood symptoms are likely to have an impact on other key outcomes in youth (e.g. education), intervening to target these can help to achieve other goals of rehabilitation (such as catching up with schoolwork, developing vocational interests, hope for the future)” (Kaur et al., 2022). These mental health challenges that children are faced with affect their future which in turn leaves many feeling hopeless. Mental health issues affect their education and ability to see more to life than the labor they are put in. Children from all parts of the world are faced with these silent burdens and https://drive.google.com/file/d/1ewdtRDB0r6swtzy1Vn5Y_Kf2OcdBCmsK/view?usp=drive_link today we explore them.

References



Kaur, H., Duncan, K., Dhakal, S., Sharma, N., Niraula, S., Pandey, R., Kumari, V., Lau, J. Y. F., & Singh, T. (2022b). Recognising and healing emotional wounds of child labourers: call to action based on the evidence and stakeholder views from India and Nepal.

Overview: Abdelaziz Taha

Reason For Selection



- To deepen the understanding of why Child Labor is such a big problem
- To share the unspoken burden that comes with child labor which is rarely brought up
- To get more people to stand up and speak on child labor
- To understand how child labor affects more than just the body and fatigue of work
- To find solutions to these struggles children go through

References

Kaur, H., Duncan, K., Dhakal, S., Sharma, N., Niraula, S., Pandey, R., Kumari, V., Lau, J. Y. F., & Singh, T. (2022). Recognising and healing emotional wounds of child labourers: call to action based on the evidence and stakeholder views from India and Nepal.

BJPsych International, 19(2), 47–50. <https://doi.org/10.1192/bji.2021.50>

Descriptive Information And Analysis

- Due to juggling school, family, friends, and hobbies, young workers experience significant levels of stress.
- Given set schedules and little control, taking up a new job raises pressure.
- Employers who overschedule might make difficult sacrifices and increase stress.
- Businesses need to understand that teenagers put other obligations ahead of their jobs.
- Employers ought to provide flexibility and modify expectations.
- Stress can be decreased by using support techniques:
 - instruction in coping mechanisms
 - Coaching and counseling
 - Social support networks and buddy systems
- Stress may be considerably decreased when employers and young employees have mutual understanding.

References

Simon, Mark. "Literature Review: Young Adult Worker Mental Health."

American Psychiatric Association Foundation, 2023,

<https://workplacementalhealth.org/employer-resources/guides-and-toolkits/literature-review-young-adult-worker-mental-health>.





Campaign Ideas

- Child work is frequently perceived in terms of its obvious negative effects (excessive hours, hazardous circumstances, lack of education).
- The effects on mental health (stress, anxiety, loss of childhood) are frequently disregarded.
- Children may seem "fine" on the outside yet have interior struggles.
- Low self-worth and little goals for the future are long-term consequences.
- Campaign focus: draw attention to child labor's hidden mental health issues
- Make use of visual storytelling (videos) that contrast inner ideas with external appearance.
- Post information on social media to increase awareness and have a long-lasting effect.

References

International Labour Organization. (2011). Assessing Psychosocial Hazards and Impacts of Child Labour.
https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/2025-05/Assessing_Psychosocial_Hazards_%26_Impact_CL_FINAL_20170804.pdf



Campaign Ideas (continued)

- Add podcast segments featuring professionals talking about psychological impacts.
- Fundraising initiatives to assist:
 - Resources for mental health programs for counseling and assistance
 - Opportunities for education for impacted children
- Expands upon previous and ongoing efforts:
 - The National Child Labor Committee used photographs to spread awareness.
 - The International Labour Organization advocates for policy reform and draws attention to psychological effects.

References

International Labour Organization. (2011). Assessing Psychosocial Hazards and Impacts of Child Labour. https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/2025-05/Assessing_Psychosocial_Hazards_%26_Impact_CL_FINAL_20170804.pdf



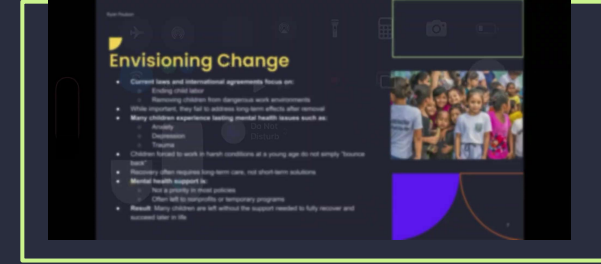
Campaign Ideas (continued)

- Add podcast segments featuring professionals talking about psychological impacts.
- Fundraising initiatives to assist:
 - Resources for mental health programs for counseling and assistance
 - Opportunities for education for impacted children
- Expands upon previous and ongoing efforts:
 - The National Child Labor Committee used photographs to spread awareness.
 - The International Labour Organization advocates for policy reform and draws attention to psychological effects.



Envisioning Change

- **Current laws and international agreements focus on:**
 - Ending child labor
 - Removing children from dangerous work environments
- While important, they fail to address long-term effects after removal
- **Many children experience lasting mental health issues such as:**
 - Anxiety
 - Depression
 - Trauma
- Children forced to work in harsh conditions at a young age do not simply “bounce back”
- Recovery often requires long-term care, not short-term solutions
- **Mental health support is:**
 - Not a priority in most policies
 - Often left to nonprofits or temporary programs
- **Result:** Many children are left without the support needed to fully recover and succeed later in life



Envisioning change : Long Term Support

Require long-term mental health programs in child labor policies

After removal, children are enrolled in support services:

- Counseling
- Education
- Reintegration support

Program structure:

- Minimum: 1 year
- Available up to 5 years

Government-funded (not just nonprofits)

Improve:

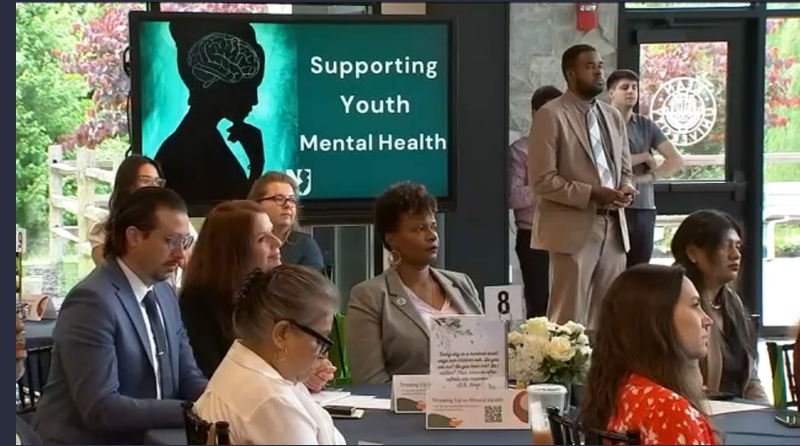
- School support systems (trained staff, resources)
- Healthcare access to mental health services

Impact:

- Better long-term outcomes
- Improved quality of life
- Stronger communities

References

Kaur, Harleen, et al. "Recognising and Healing Emotional Wounds of Child Labourers: Call to Action Based on the Evidence and Stakeholder Views from India and Nepal." *BJPsych International*, U.S. National Library of Medicine, May 2022, [pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9046832/](https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9046832/).



Conclusion

- Child Labor is usually seen from the physical aspect, demanding hours, cruel conditions, and its unfair circumstances. The goal of our project was to focus on the other side of child labor that is usually unseen, the silent burden of mental health in these children. At a young age, dealing with mental health issues such as depression, anxiety, and stress is extremely damaging to their development and it also causes issues in their future.
- Through the research my group and I presented, it made it clear that the issues of child labor do not end from just removing children from their labor places, but it is also so important to support their mental needs and recovery. It's important to stay educated on mental health and also present adequate resources to those who need it.
- The campaign ideas my group presented were posed to bring awareness to these struggles that are often invisible. We feel that with support systems and awareness through social media, education, and storytelling can definitely shift how people view child labor and its struggles that go beyond just the physical part of it. A real change requires a combination of everything my group discussed to eliminate the silent burden in child labor.



Sania Saleem

Conclusion

Child Labor is usually seen from the physical aspect, demanding hours, cruel conditions, and its unfair circumstances. The goal of our project was to focus on the other side of child labor that is usually unseen, the silent burden of mental health in these children. At a young age, dealing with mental health issues such as depression, anxiety, and stress is extremely damaging to their development and it also causes issues in their future.

Through the research my group and I presented, it made it clear that the issues of child labor do not end from just removing children from their labor places, but it is also so important to support their mental needs and recovery. It's important to stay educated on mental health and also present adequate resources to those who need it.

The campaign ideas my group presented were posed to bring awareness to these struggles that are often invisible. We feel that with support systems and awareness through social media, education, and storytelling can definitely shift how people view child labor and its struggles that go beyond just the physical part of it. A real change requires a combination of everything my group discussed to eliminate the silent burden in child labor.



References

Kaur, H., Duncan, K., Dhakal, S., Sharma, N., Niraula, S., Pandey, R., Kumari, V., Lau, J. Y. F., & Singh, T. (2022b). Recognising and healing emotional wounds of child labourers: call to action based on the evidence and stakeholder views from India and Nepal. *BJPsych International*, 19(2), 47–50.
<https://doi.org/10.1192/bji.2021.50>

Simon, Mark. "Literature Review: Young Adult Worker Mental Health." *American Psychiatric Association Foundation*, 2023.
<https://workplacementalhealth.org/employer-resources/guides-and-toolkits/literature-review-young-adult-worker-mental-health>.

International Labour Organization. (2011). Assessing Psychosocial Hazards and Impacts of Child Labour. https://www.ilo.org/sites/default/files/2025-05/Assessing_Psychosocial_Hazards_%26_Impact_CL_FINAL_20170804.pdf

Kaur, Harleen, et al. "Recognising and Healing Emotional Wounds of Child Labourers: Call to Action Based on the Evidence and Stakeholder Views from India and Nepal." *BJPsych International*, U.S. National Library of Medicine, May 2022, [pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9046832/](https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC9046832/).

UNICEF USA. (n.d.). *Child-centered solutions to address child labor in the U.S.* [Photograph].
<https://www.unicefusa.org/invisible-hands>

Government of India. (n.d.). *Stop child labour – Digital poster* [Photograph].
<https://indiancng.mygov.in/activity/samruddhi-jayraj-ghorpade/stop-child-labour-digital-poster/>